

Long camps, young blood, and tactical clarity: How India's women qualified for AFC Asian Cup 2026

From heartbreak in 2022 to triumph in Thailand: India's women's football team books a **historic AFC Asian Cup spot.**

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After years of dealing with a sense of apathy from stakeholders, cases of alleged harassment, and the Indian Women's League (IWL) being little more than an afterthought, the Indian women's national football team has quietly qualified for next year's AFC Women's Asian Cup.

This is the first time that the Blue Tigresses have made it to the continental tournament through the qualification route. In 2003, qualifiers did not exist. In 2022, India made it to the tournament as the host.

The Crispin Chettri-coached squad topped Group B after an unbeaten qualifying campaign, which included dominant wins over Mongolia (13-0), Timor Leste (4-0), and Iraq (5-0), before grinding out a decisive 2-1 win against higher-ranked Thailand.

Three years in the making

Forward Pyari Xaxa, who top-scored for India in the qualifiers with five goals, still remembers the heartbreak she and her teammates suffered at the 2022 edition of the Asian Cup. After a goalless draw against Iran in its opening game, India was forced to withdraw from the tournament after a majority of its players tested positive for COVID-19.

"When I tested positive for COVID, it felt as if the ground beneath me opened up. I cried a lot, but I hid my tears from my teammates so that they wouldn't get

disheartened. Unfortunately, most of them tested positive as well. All the hard work had gone to waste," Pyari recalls.

Cut to three years later, the 28-year-old had seemingly manifested India's ticket to Australia, the host of the next edition.

"I'd written down my dreams in my diary about five to six years back. It's free to dream. After we qualified this time, I ticked it off the list. Next, the World Cup remains."

After Pyari, Sangita Basfore was India's next highest scorer in the qualifiers, netting four times. But it was her brace in the winner-takes-all match against Thailand that capped off a journey marked by perseverance and patience. "I still haven't mentally returned from that stadium in Thailand," she says of the match, at the end of which she broke down in tears.

In 2021, during the home camp for the Asian Cup, Sangita suffered an ACL injury that sidelined her for nearly three years. While it took the Bengal player time to regain her rhythm and command in midfield, coach Chettri had always believed in